Using AI to build great cover letters

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Recap

- Cover letter is about <u>THEM</u>
- Basic structure
  - Paragraph 1: Intro + why you are applying
  - Paragraph 2-3: How you are qualified
  - Conclusion: 1-2 sentences rounding off your points and reiterating interest
  - Sign-off with name and signature

AI 101

- When most people say AI = Large Language Model
- Usually people are referring to OpenAI's ChatGPT or Anthropic's Claude
- Relies on a "chat" interface
- You tell the AI something, it responds with relevant information

V Hello you are an expert career coach. I need guidance while applying for a job.

Hello! I'd be happy to provide some guidance as you navigate the job application process. As an expert career coach, I can offer advice on a variety of topics to help you during your job search.

What specific aspects of the application process are you looking for help with? Some common areas I assist with include:

- Crafting an effective resume and cover letter
- Preparing for interviews and practicing common questions
- Identifying your key skills and strengths to highlight
- Researching companies and roles to find good fits
- Networking and leveraging your connections
- Negotiating job offers and salary

Please feel free to share more details about your situation, and I'll do my best to provide personalized guidance to support you throughout your job search. The more information you can give me about your background, goals, and any challenges you're facing, the more

Basic layout of Claude

You are an expert career coach. I need guidance finding a job.

Memory updated

Absolutely, I'd be happy to help with that! To get started, could you share a bit about your background and what kind of role or industry you're interested in? This will help me give you tailored advice on job search strategies, resume building, and networking.

Basic layout of ChatGPT

AI 101

- What kind of information can you send the AI
  - (1) Role context (framing)
  - (2) Instructions (prompts)
  - (3) Reference material
- Once the AI has returned something, you can refine it further using additional prompting
- Treat each chat as though it’s self-contained

Rules of the Road

- Treat using an AI like a collaboration
  - You need to set the AI up for success with the information you provide and what you ask from it
- The less you share with the AI, the more it will either (a) fabricate or (b) output something generic
- AI is not great at “word counts” – try going by # of paragraphs and refining with prompts (e.g. “Make the last paragraph more succient)

My advised approach to AI-generated cover letterse

- Step 1: Present framing
- Step 2: Digest JD, resume, and my thoughts on the company and role
- Step 3: Generate a cover letter as specified

Step 1: Framing

- You want to open the conversation by telling the AI what "role" it's playing
  - This improves performance significantly
- You want to specify
  - Who the AI is emulating
  - Who you are and what your "overall" needs from the AI are
  - What would constitute success by working with the AI

All prompts shared on screen will be available at
https://tinyurl.com/coverletterprompts-emory

NOTE

V You are an expert career coach who specializes in helping people prepare job application materials like cover letters. I'm a job seeker looking to be employed as a project manager at a tech company. I need your help developing a strong cover letter for an upcoming role at a company called Gainsight. We will be successful if I manage to get an interview with the company. I will give you specific instructions on how to prepare this cover letter as well as reference information for you to use while writing it. Do you understand your task?

2 / 2

Yes, I understand. As an expert career coach, I'm happy to help you develop a strong cover letter for the project manager role at Gainsight. Please provide me with the specific instructions and reference information you would like me to use, and I'll do my best to craft an effective cover letter that will help you secure an interview.

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A sample framing prompt and response

Step 2: Digest reference material

- Prompts = the instructions you want the AI to carry out
- Reference material = information the AI should consider when processing your request
  - Sometimes, the entire instruction can be to ask the AI to digest some reference material for future use

Step 2: Digest reference material

- For cover letters, you should be giving the AI 3 types of reference material:
  - (1) The job description
  - (2) Your resume/summary of most relevant experiences
  - (3) Thoughts on the company + role

Why Gainsight? At Gainsight, our mission is to be living proof you can win in business while being human first. Our values — Golden Rule, Success for All, Child-like Joy, Shoshin, and Staying Thirsty

PASTED

VA

I'm going to share 3 pieces of specific reference information with you: (1) Job description (2) My resume (3) My thoughts on the company and role I am targeting. I only want you to digest this information and keep it in mind for when I ask you to generate the cover letter.
I only want you to digest this information and keep it in mind for when I ask you to generate the cover letter.

Job description: pasted

My resume:
Education
Tools Certifications
Experience
2021

about values – they're living them.

Did you process and comprehend what I have asked?

Start and End of “Digestion” prompt

Yes, I have comprehended and processed all three pieces of reference information you've shared:

1. The detailed job description for the Project Manager role at Gainsight, including their company background, mission, values, specific responsibilities, and requirements
2. Your resume, which shows highly relevant experience including:

- Your previous internship at Gainsight in Sales Enablement
- Strong project management experience across roles
- Customer-facing experience and success metrics
- Technical certifications including Gainsight Customer Success Manager (Level I)
- MBA from Cornell with relevant club leadership

3. Your thoughtful perspective on Gainsight's culture and values, particularly noting their:

- "Human first" approach to business
- Commitment to diversity and inclusion
- Recognition as a top workplace
- Core values alignment

I understand that you want me to hold this information for when you ask me to generate the cover letter. I will not proceed with writing the letter until you give me specific instructions to do so. Would you like to provide those instructions now?

AI's response to "digestion" prompt

Step 3: Generate Cover Letter

- Tell the AI to generate a cover letter
- Specific
  - Structure
  - Writing Style
  - Miscellaneous considerations (if any)

VA

Based on what you know about this role through the job description, my background through my resume, and my interest in project management at Gainsight, I want you to generate a cover letter. I want to you to adhere to the following parameters:

Cover Letter Structure:
Paragraph 1: Intro + why you are applying
Paragraphs 2 and 3: How and why you are qualified
Conclusion: 1-2 sentences rounding off your points and reiterating interest
Sign-off with name and signature

Writing specifications:
- Use short, concise sentences and minimize repetition from my resume
- Use a relaxed yet professional tone
- Convey strong enthusiasm through my choice of language

“Generation” prompt

Dear Hiring Manager,

After experiencing Gainsight's dynamic culture as a Sales Enablement intern, I'm excited to return and tackle bigger challenges as a Project Manager. I deeply connect with Gainsight's mission of winning in business while putting people first – it's rare to find a company that so authentically lives its values while leading the customer success space.

My time at Gainsight revealed my knack for driving complex initiatives that unite people and technology. By optimizing workflows and championing cross-functional collaboration, I helped our sales team achieve tangible improvements in productivity and engagement. Now, armed with both hands-on Gainsight experience and my Customer Success Manager certification, I'm ready to take on broader project management responsibilities that directly impact our clients' success.

Cover Letter Result (Part 1)

My entrepreneurial background adds a unique dimension to my project management toolkit. Leading strategic initiatives that achieved 90%+ conversion rates while maintaining exceptional client satisfaction taught me to anticipate challenges, adapt quickly, and keep multiple stakeholders aligned toward common goals. My MBA experience at Cornell, particularly my work with Access Johnson, further developed my ability to lead diverse teams and drive inclusive collaboration – skills that resonate strongly with Gainsight's values.

I'm energized by the prospect of contributing to Gainsight's continued growth and would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my unique background can help drive your team's success.

Best regards,
Vrijen S. Attawar

Cover Letter Result (Part 2)

Why go through these steps?

- The AI isn't "magic" and it certainly doesn't know your life history – you have to set it up for success
- The more clear and compartmentalized you make your instructions and information to the AI, the better the results

Improving the output

- Improving input
  - Go beyond the resume and include relevant reflections
  - Dig deep when developing talking points for the company and role
- Further specifying “voice” related information - diction, formality, and tone
- Refinement prompting – all the instructions you give after the “output” to hone it further
  - E.g. “Make paragraph 2 more succient”, “make the tone less formal”, “use a different example in your conclusion”, etc
- Providing the AI with examples of your writing by asking it to “digest” past cover letters

Bonus: Developing Company Talking Points

- If you need stronger company related talking points, try the following
  - (1) Open a new chat and prompt the AI to help you develop talking points by asking questions one by one
    - Perform additional research on the company/role to answer effectively
  - (2) Ask the AI to summarize your responses into some key bullet points that convey the nature of your interest
  - (3) Use the output as the “thoughts on company and role” reference material for the AI in the main cover letter workflow

PASTED

VA You are an expert career coach with extensive experience helping people prepare compelling job application materials like cover letters. I am interested in writing a cover letter for Gainsight as part of my application for a project manager role. I need help developing strong talking points around my interest in this role and company. I have included the relevant job description.

Based on the job description, I want you to help flesh out my interest in this role and company by asking me probing questions. Adhere to the following rules:
- Ask me one question at a time
- Adapt your questions to focus on parts of my response that would be compelling to a potential employer
- Enhance my odds of giving you a good answer by making suggestions of things I should consider while developing my answers

Framing for “company talking points creation”

I'll help you develop compelling talking points for your cover letter. Let's start with understanding your connection to Gainsight's mission and values, since they prominently emphasize being "human first" while winning in business.

First question: What aspects of Gainsight's values (Golden Rule, Success for All, Child-like Joy, Shoshin, and Staying Thirsty) resonate most with your own professional approach? Consider sharing a specific example of how you've embodied one of these values in your work - perhaps a time when you prioritized teaching others (Success for All), brought creativity and optimism to a challenging project (Child-like Joy), or demonstrated intellectual curiosity and openness to new perspectives (Shoshin).

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Sample question from the AI

VA

I want you to review all my answers and prepare 2 paragraphs that include my most compelling reasons for wanting to join Gainsight as a project manager. Broadly cover the points I made but prioritize ones that would resonate strongly with a hiring manager given the job description in question.

Generation prompt for “company talking points”

My passion for joining Gainsight stems from my proven track record of leading customer-centric technical projects that perfectly align with your mission of being "human first" while driving business success. In my current role managing enterprise software implementations, I've consistently balanced technical excellence with stakeholder needs - much like how Gainsight helps companies like Adobe and LinkedIn deliver superior post-sale experiences. My recent success implementing a new project management framework that reduced delivery times by 30% while increasing client satisfaction scores demonstrates my commitment to the innovative, results-driven approach that has made Gainsight an industry leader.

I'm particularly drawn to this Project Manager role as it sits at the intersection of technical project delivery and customer success - an area where my experience coordinating cross-functional teams across three major digital transformation initiatives has prepared me well. Having successfully managed projects with budgets exceeding $1M while maintaining strong relationships with both technical teams and business stakeholders, I'm confident in my ability to deliver the kind of flawless project execution that Gainsight's enterprise clients expect. I'm especially excited about your commitment to continuous learning and diverse perspectives (your Shoshin value), as it mirrors my own approach of building collaborative project environments where team members are encouraged to contribute new ideas and solutions.

Copy Retry

Sample response from the AI

Litmus tests for a good cover letter

- "Name blind" test – if I were to remove the company and role name and read it, would I know exactly what job and organization it's for
  - Same test works with your name – could anyone have written this cover letter or only you
- Resume repetition test – does the content repeat resume content or extend on that point
  - Read your resume before reading your cover letter to see this clearly

Words of Caution

- The AI starts to forget details over the course of a conversation (limited context window)
  - If you notice its memory slipping, start over with a new conversation
  - Try and use a separate “chat” for each cover letter
- There is ALWAYS a risk of hallucinating, so read EVERYTHING before submission

All prompts shared on screen will be available at
https://bit.ly/49OQ0lJ

NOTE

Add me on LinkedIn @ Vrijen Attawar

THANK YOU FOR YOUR TIME